middle of May 1563, Adham Khan strode into the council hall of the Agra Fort where the nobility were occupied with state affairs. The men stood up to greet Akbar's powerful koka but Adham Khan gestured to his liegeman, who stabbed Shamsuddin Ataka Khan. As the old man stumbled into the sun-bleached courtyard, Adham Khan's men set upon him and murdered him, while Adham Khan climbed up the stairs towards the inner apartments. Hearing the shouts and the commotion, Akbar came out from the harem, tying a lungi around his waist and seizing a sword. When he realized whose bloodied body was lying in the courtyard below, he was filled with rage: 'Son of a bitch!' he cursed Adham Khan. 'Why have you killed our Ataka?' Seizing Adham Khan by the hair, Akbar struck him on the face and then ordered him to be thrown from the top of the stairs. When the first fall left Adham Khan mangled but still alive, Akbar ordered him brought up and thrown down again, head first. Akbar then went to Maham Anaga's quarters to inform her himself of the fate of her beloved but turbulent son. 'Adham killed our Ataka,' he told Maham Anaga, 'we have taken revenge on him.' Controlling her devastation with exceptional courage, Maham was able to whisper, 'You did well'. But Akbar did not allow her to visit her son's broken and ruined body, perhaps not wishing his old milk mother to know the terrible violence of Adham Khan's end. But this woman, who had lived through all the uncertain dangers of the early days of the Mughal Empire, was unable to bear the death of her son. Forty days after Adham Khan's death, Maham Anaga died, too, in grief and despair. Akbar mourned her deeply and publicly, accompanying her bier out of Agra and weeping next to her body, and commissioned a noble tomb for mother and son. The dome of the tomb is unusually vast and a light breeze blows gently through the tomb because of an intricate system of ventilation. It lies neglected in the Mehrauli area of Delhi today, having been repurposed several times by new conquerors in the following centuries. In a sort of dubious poetic justice for the ruffianly Adham Khan, though not, it must be said, for his highly accomplished mother, it has been reclaimed today as the rather louche haunt of delinquents. Maham Anaga's exceptional destiny is more clearly seen in the few miniatures in which she would later be depicted, always close to Akbar, in her distinctive yellow robes. In time, all the important Mughal noble families would jostle to be buried near the exalted dargah of Nizamuddin Auliya, within a short distance of Humayun's tomb. By burying Adham Khan near Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki's dargah, at the